

MESSI OUT TO FULFILL AMERICAN DREAM ONCE AGAIN

The legend will look to **extend his legacy** with his second Copa America title for Argentina, but Brazil and Uruguay pose formidable challenges.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

Since the FIFA World Cup 2022, football in the Americas has found its centre of gravity in Lionel Messi, the sorcerer supreme around whom the game now revolves.

Messi, who led Argentina to World Cup glory in Qatar by defeating France in the final, moved to Major League Soccer side Inter Miami after the tournament, burgeoning the interest and business of soccer, or football as it's known globally, in the United States.

In June, the USA will host the Copa America — a tournament that marked Messi's rise from a wizard on foreign soil to a legend alongside Diego Maradona.

The boy from Rosario grew up in a cauldron of criticism for not winning an international trophy like the 1986 World Cup winner.

Messi came close on three occasions (2014 — World Cup, 2015 & 2016 — Copa America) but suffered heartbreaks in the finals, eventually announcing his retirement.

In the next five years, life came full circle for him as he lifted the 2021 Copa America trophy, beating Brazil in the summit clash — one that significantly boosted his confidence to go on and win the World Cup.

At 36, Messi has admitted that there's "less time left" for him on the field, and this Copa edition could see him shine the brightest before hanging up his boots.

Since it is no longer an elusive international trophy for Argentina, it now holds the potential to create a lasting legacy, not just for Messi, but for soccer in the USA.

The dynamics of the game in the country changed in 1975 with the arrival of Pele. While Messi's move to Miami opened a fresh chapter, winning the Copa in North and South America in consecutive editions would complete his coronation as the King of America in football.

A familiar challenge

The crown, like every other, will not be easy for Argentina and Messi, as arch-rival Brazil looks to regain hegemony under new coach Dorival Junior.

Though it has had a rough ride in the FIFA World Cup 2026 qualifiers,

the surplus of young talent sets Brazil up for a new era of fluid, possession-based football, which saw Santos, São Paulo, and Flamengo clinch silverware under Dorival.

Brazil's best bet remains Vinicius Junior, who will lead the attack, having won the UEFA Champions League and La Liga title with Real Madrid this season.

While he typically plays along the left wing, the absence of captain Neymar and striker Richarlison — both out with injuries — might see him play more centrally, with Rodrygo and Raphinha on the flanks.

Brazil's assembly line of attack extends to its bench, with Endrick (17), Gabriel Martinelli (22), and Savio (20) — who directly contributed to five of Brazil's eight goals in friendlies before the Copa.

Dorival's boldest move has been excluding Casemiro, who also served as skipper of the national team at the FIFA World Cup 2022.

A perpetual pivot in the middle of the park, the Manchester United midfielder, struggling with form and consistency, was snubbed as younger options, Bruno Guimaraes and Douglas Luiz, rose in the pecking order.